

CALL FOR MINIGRANTS

ADVANCING NATURE-BASED CLIMATE ACTIONS (NBCAS) IN AFRICA: A MINI-GRANT FOR LOCALLY- LED EVIDENCE GENERATION AND POLICY INFLUENCE

Application Deadline
22ND JULY 2026

Partners



Radboud University



Project Funders



Government
of Canada

Gouvernement
du Canada



Economic
and Social
Research Council

A.) About Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN)

The Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN) is an international think tank of over 400 researchers and policymakers, with a significant portion (30%) being policymakers holding National Focal Points across 41 African countries. ARIN fosters a dynamic environment where researchers, policymakers, and practitioners working across Africa can exchange knowledge and expertise. The network operates by gathering evidence from diverse African contexts. This rich pool of information is then strategically leveraged to inform policy development, capacity building initiatives, and ultimately, achieve impactful results across communities and governments. ARIN leverages its deep well of experience in generating and consolidating evidence on effective interventions across Africa's most critical strategic sectors and themes. Recognising the continent's wealth of underutilised research, innovation, and best practices, ARIN provides a unique platform for the science-policy interface. This platform bridges the gap by facilitating the sharing, profiling, and leveraging the best research and impactful practices from diverse African contexts. Through this peer-to-peer exchange, ARIN empowers stakeholders to inform transformative policy action across the continent.

B.) Background and Rationale

Africa is at the centre of overlapping crises: climate change, biodiversity loss, and socio-economic vulnerability. These challenges are tightly linked and reinforce one another. Climate change is degrading ecosystems, shifting species distributions, and increasing extreme weather events. At the same time, biodiversity loss is weakening ecosystem resilience, reducing communities' ability to adapt, and heightening threats to livelihoods, food security, water systems, and human health, especially for vulnerable and resource-dependent populations. Rapid environmental change is already pushing species beyond their capacity to adapt, driving migration and extinction, disrupting ecosystems, and weakening the essential services they provide to communities.

Biodiversity loss also accelerates climate change. When forests, wetlands, and other critical ecosystems are converted for large-scale agriculture, urban growth, or industrial development, carbon sinks are diminished, greenhouse gas emissions rise, and the planet's natural ability to regulate climate is weakened.

These intertwined crises threaten food security, water availability, living conditions, and human health, yet current global commitments under the Paris Agreement remain insufficient to avert catastrophic climate change, while the Kunming–Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework faces a formidable challenge in halting ecosystem degradation and biodiversity loss.

Despite these challenges, the climate–biodiversity nexus also presents a critical opportunity. The IPCC Sixth Assessment Report underscores that safeguarding biodiversity and ecosystems is fundamental to climate-resilient development and effective adaptation and mitigation. Responding to this imperative requires integrated, systems-based approaches that move beyond siloed interventions.

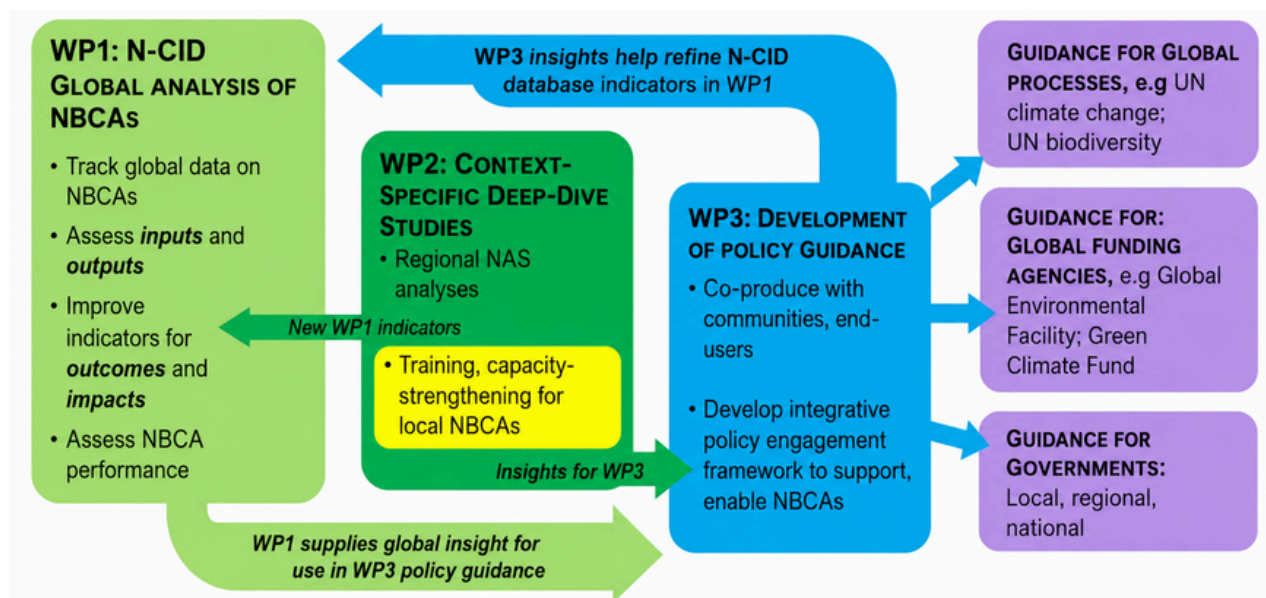
C.) About the BIOCAM4 Project

The Biodiversity Integration in Climate Adaptation and Mitigation Actions, for Planet, People and Human Health (BIOCAM4) project is funded by Government of Canada's New Frontiers in Research Fund (NFRF), the German Science Foundation (Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft – DFG) and UKRI. The project is led by York University in partnership with the Institute for Sustainability Studies (IDOS), Radbound University, The Africa Research and Impact Network, Greater Verunga Transboundary Collaboration (Rwanda), Solution for Environment and Development- CATIE (Peru). The mini-grant scheme will be funded by DFG through a contract between IDOS and ARIN.

The project advances three main objectives through research co-creation and policy engagement at local and global levels to strengthen capacity for Nature-Based Climate Actions (NBCAs), as shown in Figure 1. NBCAs are integrated approaches that use the sustainable management, conservation, and restoration of ecosystems to address climate change while improving biodiversity and human well-being. They include interventions such as ecosystem-based adaptation, agroecology, and landscape restoration, and are grounded in locally led, context-specific solutions informed by both scientific and indigenous knowledge. By linking climate resilience, biodiversity conservation, and socio-economic development, NBCAs offer scalable, inclusive, and policy-relevant solutions across diverse African landscapes. These objectives are:

- i.) Conduct a comprehensive global mapping and analysis of NBCAs and develop an open-access database to provide insights into their distribution, patterns, and performance. These global trends will inform international climate and biodiversity processes.
- ii.) Undertake context-specific studies of NBCA dynamics in four highly biodiverse localities across two regions: the Virunga and Lake Victoria regions in East Africa, and the Trifinio and Brunca regions in Central America. This work examines how biophysical, cultural, institutional, and governance factors shape community action, actor interactions, and resulting outputs, outcomes, and impacts. The findings will strengthen global performance assessments and provide evidence-based, justice-oriented guidance for policy at multiple levels.

iii.) Co-create knowledge mobilization and policy outreach strategies that translate research findings into guidance for more equitable funding and resource allocation. This will strengthen the capacity of local actors to design, implement, and sustain effective and inclusive NBCAs in the project's focus areas and beyond.



The BioCAM4 project advances this vision through Nature-Based Climate Actions (NBCAs), multi-actor, cross-sectoral interventions that embed biodiversity considerations within climate adaptation and mitigation strategies. NBCAs represent a transformative pathway for achieving co-benefits across ecosystem integrity, sustainable livelihoods, and human health outcomes, while directly contributing to global frameworks such as the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA), the Kunming–Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework (GBF), and national commitments under Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and National Adaptation Plans (NAPs).

In practice, NBCAs include interventions such as protecting and restoring forests, wetlands, and marine ecosystems; rewilding degraded landscapes; promoting climate-smart and biodiversity-friendly agriculture; and integrating ecosystem services into local adaptation planning. These actions are increasingly implemented through collaborations among governments, cities, private sector actors, civil society, and Indigenous and local communities. When effectively designed, NBCAs deliver multiple co-benefits, including improved food and water security, enhanced ecosystem services, strengthened resilience, preservation of traditional knowledge, and better health and livelihood outcomes.

However, NBCAs are not without challenges. Poorly designed interventions can undermine both biodiversity and social outcomes, for example, monoculture tree-planting focused solely on carbon sequestration can erode local biodiversity, while large-scale infrastructure such as hydropower may disrupt ecosystems and livelihoods.

Rapid environmental change further complicates planning and implementation, while the urgency to scale solutions can obscure critical considerations of equity, inclusion, and the rights of vulnerable populations. Moreover, NBCAs remain fragmented, underfunded, and insufficiently integrated, falling far short of the scale required to address the climate–biodiversity crisis.

A central constraint is the persistent lack of context-specific, locally grounded evidence on the effectiveness of NBCAs, particularly in African contexts. Existing frameworks for tracking climate action often focus on inputs and outputs, with limited attention to outcomes and long-term impacts across ecological, socio-economic, and health dimensions. In addition, the knowledge, priorities, and agency of local communities, essential for locally led adaptation, are frequently underrepresented in both research and implementation. Consequently, African experiences remain insufficiently captured in global datasets and evidence systems, limiting policy learning, weakening accountability, and constraining the effective targeting of climate and biodiversity finance.

To address these gaps, the BioCAM4 project, through its Work Package 2 (WP2), focuses on context-specific deep-dive studies that examine the socio-ecological, institutional, Cultural and governance dynamics shaping NBCAs at local levels. These studies adopt participatory and interdisciplinary approaches to understand how NBCAs are designed, implemented, and experienced, and to assess their outputs, outcomes, and long-term impacts. The insights generated contribute to improving global methodologies for tracking NBCAs, strengthening evidence-based policy guidance, and informing more equitable and effective resource allocation.

D.) About the Biocam4 Mini-Grant Scheme

Against this backdrop, the BioCAM4 Mini-Grant Fellowship Programme, implemented by the Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN), seeks to expand this work across Africa by supporting early-career researchers to conduct high-quality, policy-relevant case studies in their countries. The programme provides a structured platform to generate locally grounded evidence, build research capacity, and strengthen collaboration among African researchers and policymakers. Beyond producing evidence, the fellowship is designed to reinforce Africa’s science-policy interface by ensuring research informs decision-making from community and subnational systems to national adaptation planning and global climate and biodiversity processes. It also contributes to ARIN’s broader mission of building a continental community of “evidence leaders” who can translate research into action. Ultimately, the programme will help support the design, scaling, and financing of inclusive, effective, and locally led NBCAs that advance adaptation, biodiversity, and sustainable development goals.

Goals and Objectives of the Mini-Grant Call

Overall Goal

To generate locally grounded, policy-relevant evidence on Nature-Based Climate Actions (NBCAs) in Africa to inform climate, biodiversity, and adaptation decision-making at national, regional, and global levels.

Specific Objectives

Specific objectives of the mini-grant call under the BIOCAM4 Project includes to:

1. Support high-quality case studies that assess the design, implementation, and outcomes of NBCAs across diverse African socio-ecological contexts.
2. Examine the socio-ecological, institutional, and governance factors influencing NBCA performance using participatory and interdisciplinary approaches.
3. Produce actionable policy insights while building the capacity of early-career African researchers to contribute to evidence-based climate and biodiversity decision-making.

E.) Grant Amount

Each fellow selected under the BIOCAM4 Programme mini-grant scheme will be awarded a total of **€3,000** as catalytic funding to support the implementation of their proposed research. This allocation is intended to cover essential research-related costs, including fieldwork, stakeholder engagement, data collection and analysis. Fellows are expected to manage the funds prudently, ensuring alignment with approved workplans and delivering high-quality, policy-relevant outputs within the available budget.

F.) Duration of the Mini-Grant Scheme

The Mini-Grant Fellowship under the BIOCAM4 Programme will be implemented over a period of **8 months**, during which selected fellows are expected to complete their proposed research activities, engage in programme learning events, and deliver all required outputs, including case study reports and policy briefs.

G.) Eligibility Criteria

- a) Early-career status: Be an early-career researcher, practitioner, or policymaker, typically within 5 years of completing your highest degree or with comparable professional experience in climate, biodiversity, or related fields.
- b) Institutional affiliation: Be affiliated with a recognized academic, research, policy, or practitioner institution at the time of application and throughout the grant period.
- c) Geographic focus: Conduct research or implementation activities in Africa, with a clear local, national, or regional focus.

d)Thematic alignment: Submit a two-page (500-700 words) concept note that clearly aligns with BioCAM4 priorities, especially integrating biodiversity into climate adaptation and mitigation and generating co-benefits for ecosystems, livelihoods, and human health, with clear feasibility of the proposed methodology and budget.

e)ARIN Fellowship engagement: Be an existing ARIN Fellow or show willingness to join and actively participate in the ARIN Fellowship activities, including knowledge-sharing and collaborative learning activities.

f)Grant exclusivity: Not be receiving another ARIN mini-grant at the time of application or during the proposed project period.

g)Interdisciplinary and stakeholder engagement (preferred): Demonstrate the ability to work across disciplines and engage relevant stakeholders, including communities, policymakers, and practitioners.

H.) Expected Outcome

Each selected fellow will deliver:

- a) A refined research proposal incorporating feedback from the selection process.
- b) An 8,000-word case study report (working paper) analyzing NBCAs within their country context, and a policy brief summarizing key findings and actionable recommendations for decision-makers. With the help of ARIN, these products (academic papers) may be peer-reviewed and transformed into book chapters or journals and articles depending on their quality and depth.
- c) Active participation in ARIN webinars, dialogues, and peer-learning sessions

I.) How to Apply

Applicants must submit a complete application package containing the materials listed below. Incomplete applications will not be considered.

i.A one-page motivation letter explaining the applicant's interest in the BioCAM4 Mini-Grant Fellowship, the relevance of their expertise, and how their work aligns with Nature-Based Climate Actions (NBCAs).

ii.A curriculum vitae (CV) of no more than four pages, highlighting academic qualifications, research experience, policy engagement, and relevant publications or outputs.

iii.A concept note of up to two pages (700-1500 words) clearly describing the proposed research, and the feasibility of the proposed methodology and budget.

iv.Two reference letters from individuals familiar with the applicant's academic or professional work. Referees should be senior academics or policymakers able to comment on the applicant's research capacity and potential.

All application materials must be submitted electronically as a **single PDF** file to the email address provided in the call for applications, using the following subject line: BioCAM4 Mini-Grant Application – [Your Full Name]

Applications are to be submitted via **e-mail** to a.irungu@arin-africa.org, copying a.obonyo@arin-africa.org , and e.akinyi@arin-africa.org, **not later than 22 July, 2026.**

J.) Contact

For any inquiry, please contact: a.obonyo@arin-africa.org copying e.akinyi@arin-africa.org.